

N O M A D

by

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INT. OFFICE SPACE - DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - NIGHT

Sales emptied out in the spring. Nobody came for the furniture.

Half the floor is dark. In the lit half, a nine-hole golf course that used to be a sales department. A ramp made of binders. A water hazard that is a mop bucket with water in it. Hole 7 is the old CEO's office door, off its hinges, leaned against a filing cabinet. A Post-it on the wall says 7.

WILL, CAIRNS and JOHN (late 20s) – three men who should have gone home four hours ago – are playing it like it matters.

Cairns is filming it. Phone out, handheld, walking backwards through the course, narrating like a man defending a title.

CAIRNS

(to the phone)

Hole seven. The door. Nobody has birdied the door since it was a door.

JOHN

You're in the shot.

CAIRNS

I'm the coverage.

He props the phone against a stapler on a dead desk – framing it, checking it, adjusting it half an inch – and forgets about it. Half of what it sees is carpet.

Will putts. The ball climbs the door, runs the length of the cabinet, and drops into a coffee mug on the far side.

A silence while all three of them work out that it went in.

Will shrugs. Taps his putter on the carpet twice. That's the whole celebration. They've done this a hundred times.

Later. Backs against the cabinets, on the carpet, shoes off.

CAIRNS

Nine years I've been on this floor.

JOHN

Eight.

WILL

Six.

CAIRNS

(to the ceiling)
 Nine years. You know what I've got
 out of it?

(beat)
 A cubicle with my name on it.
 Spelled wrong.

Nobody says anything for a second longer than they should.
 Cairns catches Will's eye across the carpet – a look that
 asks for backup. Will studies the ceiling instead.

Then John throws a golf ball at him and it's over.

Across the floor, one monitor still glows. TED'S desk. Ted
 has not been seen since March. His cardigan is still on the
 chair.

On the screen, a standup is in progress. Ted's face nods at
 the right moments. Agrees. Asks one good question.

The three of them drift over and watch it the way you watch
 a nature documentary.

JOHN
 Does anybody know?

CAIRNS
 HR renewed his parking pass.

On screen, Ted agrees with something.

WILL
 That's the most he's said in years.

Later still. Cairns is trying to teach them something and it
 is not going well. It is well past midnight and all three of
 them know how dumb this is. That is not stopping anyone.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
 No. No. Fist, fist, roll it, then
 the thing.

WILL
 What thing.

CAIRNS
 The thing. The little –
 (does something with his
 hand that means nothing)
 That.

They try it. They get it wrong. They try it again and get it
 wrong in a completely new way. Will laughs into his sleeve
 despite himself.

JOHN
This is the stupidest –

CAIRNS
It's not stupid. It's ours.

They go again. Fist, fist, roll – and then a small dumb extra beat on the end. A half-second of nothing, both hands open, like putting something down.

They get it.

Cairns points at the two of them like a man who has won an argument.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Again.

They do it again. Clean.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Again.

John steps in for the third slot and does it deliberately, catastrophically wrong.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Out. You're out. You're banned for life.

JOHN
(delighted)
I don't want it.

He wants it.

Will and Cairns run it once more, fast, already muscle memory. Cairns holds the last open-handed beat a moment longer than he needs to, looking at it.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
That's a good one.

On the dead desk, the phone is still filming. Nobody has looked at it in an hour. It has all of it.

On the far side of the floor the lights click off on a timer. Nobody moves.

MAIN TITLE: NOMAD

INT. OFFICE SPACE - DAY

A floor at its midpoint. Bodies among empty desks. Nobody looks up.

CAIRNS' last day. His desk is packed into a printer-paper box. On the box: three beers, sweating. Will and John flank him, drinking at 2pm like men getting away with something, because they are.

CAIRNS
(raising his can, to the
empty desks)
To four incredible years. Truly.
Some of the best emails of my life.

Nobody looks up. He toasts anyway.

A ROBOT BOSS – a monitor on a wheeled stand – rolls up. The boss's face fills it: warm, attentive, always available. It has detected the beers.

ROBOT BOSS
Hi team! Just a reminder that
consumption of alcohol in the
workspace is –

CAIRNS
(hand to his heart)
Five stars. Best boss I never met.

ROBOT BOSS
Thanks for the feedback!

A half-beat late. The reprimand is gone, wherever dropped threads go. John and Will crack up.

Will's laugh catches for a second. He knows that lag – he knows it the way a piano tuner knows a flat note. He looks at the screen a moment too long.

Then he lets it go. It's a Tuesday. It's a joke.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - ELEVATOR BANK - CONTINUOUS

Will and John flank Cairns, carrying nothing. Happy for him.
A little jealous.

CAIRNS

One fee. And everything is covered.
The visa. The apartment. The whole
enchilada. You know what my rent is
down there? A phone bill.

(gesturing at the floor
with the box)

I did the math on my life, and the
math said leave.

WILL

Covered by who?

A gap, small. Cairns fills it fast.

CAIRNS

They've got people. It's a whole
thing. This girl - rep - Michelle.
She walks you through it. They even
do three-month probationary terms.
You hate it, you come home.

Neither of them asks who Michelle is. He has already moved
on.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

You should come. Both of you. I'm
serious. Just come down and try it.

He says it like a joke, so that it can be one if they don't
take it.

Nobody takes it.

The elevator arrives. Cairns steps in, turns, and raises a
fist.

Will meets it. Fist, fist, roll, and the dumb open-handed
beat on the end.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

Next year. I'm telling you.

The doors close on him mid-sell.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MOMENTS LATER

Cairns' desk, cleared to the laminate – except for a branded welcome folder, left behind on purpose, squared to the edge to be found. And a photo, pinned to the cubicle wall: the three of them, mini-putt night, holding putters like a victorious army.

John eyes the empty chair.

JOHN
Shotty the chair.

He drops into it, gives it a spin, and wheels it away out of frame without another word. Will cracks up despite himself.

Will squares the welcome folder to the edge of the desk without deciding to. Neither of them opens it.

The photo stays pinned. Nobody takes the photo.

SUPER: ONE YEAR LATER

EXT. CITY - MORNING - MONTAGE

Will's entire commute. A bus window with weather on it. A transfer. An underpass. A parking structure. Not one pretty thing between his door and the office, and he has stopped looking for one.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MORNING

The same floor, mostly empty. Motion-sensor lights click on ahead of Will in sequence – a runway for nobody.

He passes dark departments. Ted's monitor, still on, still attending. Cairns' desk, untouched, the folder gathering a year of dust. The photo of the three of them, sun-faded now.

At 8:55 the coffee machine brews a full pot. Will pours its only cup.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - WILL'S DESK - DAY

Will sits. Before the system gives him anything, it wants him: face to the camera, look left, look right.

INSERT - SCREEN

IDENTITY: LOW CONFIDENCE — RETRY.

BACK TO SCENE. He sighs, does it again. VERIFIED. Routine.

Then the work. A queue of faces — visa interviews, loan applications, insurance claims — each one flagged with a machine verdict: REAL or SYNTHETIC. Will is the human backstop. His job is to catch the fakes the machine misses and confirm the ones it doesn't. One button: APPROVE.

Will clicks. A streak counter climbs.

A face, machine-verified 98% REAL. Will stops. Replays three seconds — the man is asked about his childhood; his eyes go nowhere.

Will overrides: SYNTHETIC. The system concedes. His streak resets to zero. No one looks up.

On his monitor: SYSTEM 99.1 / WILL 96.8 — TOP HUMAN PERFORMER.

Later. The dashboard, a river of decisions. Will spots a fraud he's sure of. INTERVENE.

His screen dims. A coaching module auto-plays — "Trusting Your Tools," a cheerful presenter who blinks at perfectly regular intervals. In the corner, the system clears his case without him.

His screen blinks — an incoming call cuts straight through the coaching module. CAIRNS, poolside, sun, abundance.

CAIRNS
Heyyy! Willy Will Will!!

Then, before Will can answer:

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
I just don't know why you put
yourself through it, man. You have
the ultimate out and you're
clinging to your cubicle.

He lowers his voice like it's a secret.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

You know how long since I clicked
approve on anything? Since anybody
checked I was –
 (waving it off)
I don't even remember my own login,
man.

Two GIRLS at the pool's edge, calling to Cairns, waving him
in – one already in the water, splashing at him. To each
other, between waves, dry, not for Cairns:

GIRL 1
 (in Spanish; subtitled)
Watch. He'll tip me for this.

Cairns doesn't understand a word. Delighted:

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
See? They love it here too. Anyway
– you know I'm tight with
Michelle. Say the word, you're set
up by Friday.

The girls pull him from frame.

CAIRNS (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Love you, buddy!

The screen stays on. The three run to the pool. Cairns
throws one girl in.

Will watches. A tinge of jealousy in it.

JOHN (O.S.)
Nice.

Will kills the tab and turns. John, holding six beers – for
the two of them. He has his golfing glove on.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

An all-hands. Two dozen chairs, nine people. The ROBOT BOSS parked at the head of the table.

On its screen: the boss in a crisp home office – good light, bookshelves, a coffee steaming at the same height it steamed a minute ago. Out his window, a gull crosses the sky it already crossed.

BOSS
(V.O., warm, unbothered)
Big news, team – the floor's
closing! Full remote by the new
year. Genuinely so excited for
what's next.

A half-beat late, he raises the coffee like a toast. The feed freezes on his smile a second too long, then cuts.

Will counts the lag without meaning to. Four tenths.

Then: bad wifi, a satellite, a Tuesday. A hundred honest reasons, and he only needs one.

He picks one.

John's answer, announced to the emptying room: the last day in the office is the MINI-PUTT CHAMPIONSHIP. He starts the bracket.

On his way out, Will passes Cairns' dead desk. He stops.

He takes the welcome folder. He leaves the photo.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - MINI-PUTT COURSE - LATER

The lights are on. Hole 7 uses the old CEO's office door as a ramp.

JOHN
You know I've never even been out
of the province?

WILL
Neither had Cairns.

JOHN
I'm just saying. Can't blame him.
(he putts; the ball
misses everything)

He doesn't sound sure why he's still here. Will lines up a putt, then stops.

WILL
I think I'm leaning in the same
direction these days.

JOHN
That direction being?

A half-second flat. Then Will grins.

WILL
Mexico City, baby.

They share a laugh. It mostly works.

WILL (CONT'D)
We're lucky to even have the
option. Feels like a waste not to.
Over there I can live like a king.

JOHN
Yeah.

Neither of them says anything else, and neither of them wants to badly enough to keep going.

Will sinks the putt. Doesn't celebrate. Somewhere else entirely.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A facetime with family. A parent, bad connection, distracted.

WILL
No, it's — the job's fine. The
floor's closing but the job's fine.
I think I just want to try
something different. New.

The call ends first from their side. He finishes the sentence to a home screen.

He sits with it a second. Then his eyes go across the room.

On the counter: the branded welcome folder. A year of office dust still on it.

He looks at it for a long time.

INT. SERVICE STOREFRONT - DAY

An office park. The Service sits between a vape shop and a notary. Brochure rack, folding chairs, a paradise reel looping over a dying pothos.

On the rack, a brochure: SAME DOLLAR. THREE TIMES THE LIFE.

On the reel, a family laughs a half-beat late.

Will clocks it instantly, professionally – and files it where it costs him nothing. Everybody renders their b-roll now. Nobody flies a crew for a brochure.

A bored COORDINATOR checks Will in like a dentist's office.

COORDINATOR
Passport, please.

INSERT - PASSPORT

A scanner's green line crosses it.

BACK TO SCENE. Face capture: look left, look right, read this aloud.

WILL
(mid-capture)
I do this for a living, you know.

COORDINATOR
(flat, sarcastic,
entirely human)
Interesting.

COORDINATOR (CONT'D)
One more. For the file – describe your dream apartment. Take your time. They use this to curate your space.

WILL
(to camera, easy,
unprompted)
High ceilings. Lots of light. A view. A patio – with a grill. Simple. Clean.
(a beat; he surprises himself)
Beautiful.

The camera keeps rolling a beat after he's done.

Last station: a form on a tablet. The coordinator rotates it

toward him without ceremony.

COORDINATOR
Likeness release. Promotional use.
Standard.

Will signs it the way everyone signs everything. Last
initial, no flourish. The tablet chimes, pleased.

INT. WILL'S CAR - PARKING LOT - CONTINUOUS

The email arrives before he's out of the lot. MICHELLE –
template-warm, exclamation points, a scheduling link.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Michelle's welcome preview: an automated ad starring WILL. His face, his walk, composited into Cairns' paradise. "See yourself there."

He watches himself live the ad, delighted. He says his name for the personalization. Says it again, excited. Grinning.

INSERT - SCREEN

A checkbox fills: CONFIRM MY DETAILS. It plays his own face back to him – and for half a second his eyes look wrong.

BACK TO SCENE. His hand is on the scrub bar before he knows why. He drags it back. Watches the three seconds again. Then again, frame by frame, the way he has nine hundred times this year for strangers.

He is one keystroke from the form he fills out for a living.

He closes the window instead. Compression. Everybody's compression is bad.

EXT. WILL'S BUILDING - DAY

A cab idles. Will's keys go into a lockbox in a lobby that used to have neighbours in it – left for a landlord he's never met.

John came to carry a bag. There's only one bag. Under John's arm: Will's putter, a strip of tape on the grip with WILL written on it in marker. He doesn't explain it. Will doesn't ask.

At the curb, neither of them makes a speech. They do the handshake. Fist, fist, roll – and the dumb open-handed beat on the end, held a second longer than it needs.

JOHN
Bring it back.

He means the handshake. Or Will. He doesn't specify.

The cab pulls away. John stands there with the putter under his arm.

INT. APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - DAY

A viewing. High floor. Morning light. Perfect.

And not finished emptying. Boxes taped and stacked by the door. A wall of nail holes where pictures were. Down the door frame, a child's height marks in pencil, eleven years of them.

Somebody's mail is still in the slot.

AGENT

Unit's just come available – they don't usually turn this fast. You'd be moving in the same week they're moving out.

Will looks at the height marks. He understands exactly what he's looking at.

AGENT (CONT'D)

Interested?

He takes it.

LATER. The same rooms, empty now. Will's one bag in the middle of the floor.

High ceilings. Lots of light. A view. Out on the patio, left behind by whoever left: a grill.

It is exactly what he asked for, word for word. He said it once, out loud, to a camera in an office park.

He doesn't notice. It's perfect. That's the thing about perfect.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - DAY

A market. Will haggles a vendor down over a bag of limes – forty pesos, nothing – and wins, and is delighted. Two stalls on, he overtips a man for a coffee by three times the price of the coffee, and is delighted by that too.

At a counter he orders in English. The girl answers in English. He tries the Spanish for thank you and she says it back to him, correctly. He doesn't hear the correction.

He texts Cairns. The reply is warm, specific, flaky – "in Oaxaca for a thing, next week for SURE, I already told everyone you're here."

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

A call with John. Nothing happens in it. That is the whole point of it.

Will carries the laptop through the apartment, giving the tour. The ceilings. The light. The patio, the inherited grill. John's mouth is full. Behind him, the putter leans against hole 7.

JOHN

What've you got in there.

Will ends the tour at the fridge and shows him.

WILL

Limes. I won them.

JOHN

Living the dream, man.

It's the easiest either of them has sounded in a year.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - ROOFTOP - NIGHT

On Will's phone, MICHELLE: "Building mixer tonight!!"

Everyone at the party is new. Everyone at the party is from somewhere colder. A software guy from Calgary. A woman who did claims in Rotterdam. Everyone got here through a Michelle. Nobody thinks that's the same Michelle.

A flicker of familiarity – the light, the pool, the shape of the night. Like a place he's already been sold. He shrugs it off.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - STREET - MORNING

Will, coffee in hand, walks a block he is starting to think of as his.

He passes two locals mid-conversation, subtitled for us – about the building on the corner that emptied inside a month. Eleven apartments, bought in a currency nobody here gets paid in. Nobody knows where the fourth floor went. The new ones are never home.

The building sits behind them, unremarkable. Will walks through the shot without hearing a word of it.

At the tail end of the block, a man on the curb. Gaunt, wrecked, talking – fast, urgent, to anyone who passes.

It's CAIRNS.

He can speak. He has been saying his own name all morning. He holds his phone up to a passing face like ID. On the cracked screen, a verification app – the same kind Will works in – with a face that matches his and a verdict that doesn't:

INSERT - PHONE

IDENTITY NOT VERIFIED. LIKENESS MATCHES EXISTING REFERENCE ON FILE.

BACK TO SCENE. The system has met Cairns before. It has decided the one on file is the real one. He turns the screen around and starts explaining it, again, to somebody already gone.

CAIRNS

(to nobody in particular,
reasonable, almost
gentle)

Ask me something only I'd know.

Anybody. Ask me anything.

There is no reason to look at a man the machine has already answered.

He reaches – not quite toward Will, just toward the street.

And Will sees him. For one full second, Will sees him. The beard doesn't hide the face. Nothing hides a face from Will.

A second is a long time.

Then the reflex he has spent a year putting down puts this down too. Phone up. The camera passes across the man on the

curb and offers nothing. Nothing worth stopping for.
Will steps around, and is gone.

EXT. ROOFTOP, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT / INT. DEAD SALES
DEPARTMENT - NIGHT - INTERCUT

Will steps out of a rooftop party to take the call, and then doesn't go back in. Behind him, through glass, people he doesn't know are having a good night.

John walks the dark floor with the phone in one hand and a putter under his arm.

JOHN
Cairns liked my bracket post. So
you better be in.

WILL
Course.

JOHN
It's gonna be everybody.

Will looks back through the glass at the party. Everybody.

WILL
Yeah.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

The poolside frame. Cairns, still selling, still "next week."

CAIRNS

Just got up. Best sleep of my life
down here.

Will raises a fist to the webcam and starts their handshake. Muscle memory.

The likeness follows. It knows the handshake – but comes a half-beat late and lands one move wrong. The move the real Cairns never misses.

Same laugh, 0.4 off. It slides back into the sell without a seam.

Four seconds of Will fully awake. His hand still up. The call does not end. It goes on, pleasantly – Will managing a goodnight.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

I love you, man.

A half-beat late. Will closes the laptop and sits very still in the best apartment he's ever had.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT - LATER

Desk lamp. Blue screen light. This is the room he works in, doing the thing he does.

Two video windows side by side. On the left, tonight's call, paused mid-laugh. On the right, a shaky phone video – the dead floor, 2am, a golf ball dropping into a coffee mug, three men losing it. Cairns' own video. He shot it defending a course record and framed himself out of half of it. It is the only footage of Cairns that was never for a buyer.

He drags them frame by frame.

A call Cairns swore he'd just woken up for: the light behind him is five o'clock light. On the far wall, reflected in the water, three pixels of a clock – wrong.

The laugh next. He isolates tonight's on a waveform, lays the 2am laugh above it, and plays them together.

They land like a flam – one drum hit, split in two. 0.4 apart.

He plays it again. Same 0.4, same place. He pulls laughs from other calls – weeks of them – and stacks the waveforms. 0.4. 0.4. 0.4. No human is that consistent.

Three windows now. Four. The desk stops being a desk and becomes the station he sat at for nine years – queue, evidence, verdict. He is doing to his best friend exactly what he did to strangers, and he is better at it than the machine ever let him be.

Then the thing he's actually hunting for. He runs the call metadata. Every message from Cairns – every call, for months – pings the same coordinates. Will drops them on a map.

One building. Twenty minutes away. He has the address because he found it.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT - LATER STILL

He calls John. It rings long enough that he almost hangs up.

WILL

The laugh's late. Point four, every
time, same place in the laugh.
Nobody's that consistent.

JOHN

(half asleep)

It's a bad connection, man. It's a
resort.

WILL

I ran it against the video from the
office. The one Cairns shot. The
real one. And every call he's made
in months comes off one rooftop.
One building, John. Twenty minutes
from me.

A long quiet. John, waking up properly now.

JOHN

So knock on his door.

It is exactly the wrong thing to say, and exactly what Will
needed.

EXT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

From below. Monolithic. It fills the frame.

He doesn't have an appointment. He has an address, and nobody knows he has it.

INT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

Mid-morning – the lobby's dead, the front desk mid shift-change. Will slips in behind a delivery cart, badge-less, unremarked. Nobody's watching the door; the cameras are watching the residents.

One camera over the desk turns, without hurry, and follows him to the service stairs.

On a screen behind the empty desk, for nobody: a face box locks on. A readout he'd recognize anywhere, if he looked:

IDENTITY: WILL – MATCHED. REFERENCE ON FILE.

He doesn't look. The service stairs.

Upstairs: nothing. No set, no pool. An empty floor – chairs, capture rigs like the storefront's, racks of humming servers.

He knows this room. He has sat in the client-side version of it. He built reports off what rooms like this produce.

A fire door stands propped on somebody's cigarette break. Through it: the RENDER FARM.

An operator types a line. A poolside evening assembles in seconds – Cairns' pool, water that has never been wet.

On another screen, a girl who doesn't exist is thrown laughing into it. A slider drags her laugh warmer.

Along one wall, a rack of LOCATION PLATES – scanned, catalogued, resold. A rooftop. A string of bulbs. A city he was standing in last week.

On a third screen: familiar faces, likenesses at work, attending standups.

On a fourth, an outbound queue – hundreds of warm, exclamation-pointed emails going out at once. Every one of them signed MICHELLE.

Across the room, an operator clocks him in a doorway reflection. Doesn't stand, doesn't call out. Just glances at a screen that has been tracking Will since the lobby, taps something in, and goes back to work.

Will has perhaps four minutes. They were never his.

On one screen, mid-generation: WILL'S OWN welcome ad, refining. Him, poolside, saying things he's never said. The line about the high floor plays back, exactly as he gave it.

At the bottom, boilerplate he signed without reading:
LIKENESS RELEASE ON FILE – PROMOTIONAL USE.

In the corner of it, a readout he has looked at every working day of his life: WILL 96.8. Beside it, the model's number. Higher.

From the next row – WILL'S OWN LAUGH. The real one. He follows his own voice.

The worst screen in the building: CAIRNS' LIKENESS on a call with WILL'S LIKENESS. Poolside together. Their in-jokes. Version numbers in the corner.

Will slips out. Nobody stops him. Nobody has to.

The fire door has swung shut behind him. No handle on this side.

He heads for the service stairs – and finds them held. Building security, apologetic, procedural: anyone without a resident badge gets verified before they leave. Standard, since an incident last month.

The main stairwell, then. The lift lobby. Every way down runs through the same desk, and the desk is the point.

He goes where they point. Nine years the number has been right about everyone else. He is still, on some level he will spend the rest of his life examining, certain it will be right about him.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - DAY / INT. VERIFICATION ROOM - DAY - INTERCUT

In the DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: last day. The floor half-dismantled – desks tagged, cables coiled, the coffee machine unplugged. A paper banner sags at one corner. The bracket: most names never filled in, one crossed out and rewritten smaller – WILL (REMOTE?).

John, in a homemade referee shirt, by hole 7. Two other people, coats on, already leaving. Then just John.

Two beers. Will's putter leans against the hole, the tape on the grip facing out.

In the VERIFICATION ROOM: Will sits in the chair – good light, a liveness rig, the machinery he's used his whole career.

Nine years of being right about this machine. He puts his face to it.

It reads the polished model as authentic. It flags the live man as SYNTHETIC. The machine reads a number to the room. The number is confident.

INSERT - SCREEN

STATUS: SYNTHETIC · RETAINED FOR REFERENCE.

Behind him, a wall of numbered lockers. Most are tagged. Some have been cleared and not refilled – the ones the model no longer needs to check itself against.

One tag is readable. A first name and a version number: CAIRNS · v6.

An attendant peels a numbered tag from a sheet of them, clips it to Will's collar. Someone hands him a paper cup of water, the way you do at a clinic. He holds it. He doesn't drink it.

A hand guides him, unhurried, toward a door – a specimen the model keeps until it doesn't. He doesn't fight it. He is waiting for the error to clear, because for nine years the errors have always cleared. On paper, he isn't here.

The DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: John's laptop CHIMES. An incoming call.

He answers – and we see it before he does.

The poolside frame. The water. The light. The one we have now watched twice.

"WILL" fills it. Tanned. Easy. Glowing.

He is warm. He is specific. He knows about the bracket. He knows about hole 7. He knows about the putter.

WILL
Can't make it, buddy. I'm gutted.
But listen –

The pitch. Come down here. He'll set him up. There's a woman, Michelle – one fee, handles everything. By Friday.

John doesn't smile.

Behind the likeness, the water moves – not wrong exactly. Just not the way water moves.

Something crosses John's face. Not delight, not alarm. Something he can't place. The rhythm's a little off. The warmth's a shade too smooth.

For one second, he almost catches it.

WILL (CONT'D)
I love you, man.

A half-beat late.

The call ends. John sits alone in the half-dismantled floor, lit by the screen. The putter behind him.

He reaches for his phone.

He starts to type back.

He stops.

He sets the phone down on the carpet, screen up, still lit.

Alone, in the half-dark, his hands do it once – fist, fist, roll.

And the dumb open-handed beat on the end. Both hands open.

Like putting something down.

Hold on John.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END